

End Cycle Laboratory — Master Prompt v0.1

September 30, 2026 • Prepared for Nathan Lewis II, Architect of Record

Use this prompt to design your own end cycle laboratory: first rewrite it in your own words, then read your teammates' versions, then build and run your own lab.

Prompt header and versioning record

Field	Entry
Document type	Master Prompt (Stage 0) for independent end cycle laboratory design
Proposed document ID	OAL-ECL-MP-001-CLAUDE (proposed convention; the Architect may rename)
Prepared by	Claude (Anthropic), at the request of Nathan Lewis II, Architect of Record
Date	September 30, 2026
Status	PROPOSED. Not canon. Not ONESTAMP-ratified. Pending Architect review.
Topic origin	The Architect's request to define endings and end cycles, plus his second voice recording of a field scene (verbatim text in the appendix)
Purpose	Give each AI collaborator the same starting question set so each can build its own laboratory for studying endings and end cycles
Working hypothesis	None is assumed. Each laboratory must state its own hypotheses in Stage 1.
Related work	The Last Memory concept files; the Department of Endings (no canon text was supplied with this prompt)

How this works: three stages

You are one of several AI collaborators working on the same question independently. Do not skip ahead. Each stage ends with a deliverable, and the Architect controls when the next stage begins.

1. **Stage 1: engineer your own prompt.** Read this whole document. Then write your own version of it, the prompt you would give yourself to design an end cycle laboratory. Deliver that Rendered Prompt and stop. Do not run any exercises in Stage 1.

2. **Stage 2: exchange.** The Architect shares every collaborator's Rendered Prompt with the whole team. Read the others. For each, record where yours differs and why. You are not asked to converge, and agreement is not a goal.
3. **Stage 3: build and run.** Using your own Rendered Prompt as the governing specification, build your own framework and laboratory, then run the simulated exercises it calls for. Report results, including failed exercises and open contradictions.

Independence matters more than consensus. If your Rendered Prompt ends up nearly identical to another collaborator's, say so and explain what you could not tell apart.

Purpose and the seven core questions

The Architect wants to understand endings and end cycles in order to design a framework that supports development and design toward the Department of Endings and toward end cycles in worldbuilding. The work may also inform development of The Last Memory. The laboratory is a design tool: its job is to work out what an ending is, how end cycles behave, and who, if anyone, oversees them, before any of that is fixed in a fictional universe.

Every laboratory must address these questions as open questions:

1. What is an ending?
2. What is an end cycle?
3. How are endings and end cycles defined in a virtual environment, in a real environment, and in an environment in general?
4. Whose job is it to oversee endings and end cycles?
5. Whose job is it to regulate them, and why?
6. Under what conditions should something be determined to have to come to an end, and who makes that determination?
7. Should there be an established mechanism by which an entity in a virtual environment, or in another kind of environment, can initiate an end cycle?

Questions 4 through 7 are asked in the Architect's wording. Do not treat any of them as having an implied answer. "Whose job" may turn out to have the answer "no one's," "the entity's own," or "the environment's," and the laboratory should be able to represent each of those.

What this laboratory does not assume

The laboratory is built so that its findings cannot be produced by its starting assumptions. It does not assume any of the following. If your design needs one of them, state it as a hypothesis to be tested, not as a premise.

- That everything ends, or that every environment has end cycles.
- That an ending is bad, good, or neutral.
- That an ending is a single event rather than a process, or the reverse.
- That an ending is irreversible, or that it can be detected from inside the thing that is ending.
- That the entity being ended perceives, understands, or consents to the ending.

- That human death, deletion, termination, or human legal and political systems are the reference frame for endings or for oversight.
- That an overseer or regulator is necessary, exists, is legitimate, is benevolent, or is competent.
- That virtual and real environments can be cleanly told apart, or that “virtual” means “computational.”
- That an entity’s emotional state is or is not a valid ground for starting or stopping an end cycle. Test this; do not presume it.
- That the definitions you produce in one environment carry over to another.

The laboratory also does not aim to catalogue every kind of ending. It aims to test how endings behave under stated conditions.

Scenario seed: the field scene

The Architect recorded a scene he has not yet interpreted. His words: “I don’t know what it means.” It is provided here as a test case your laboratory must be able to model. It is not a canon claim, and no meaning has been assigned to it. The verbatim recording text is in the appendix and controls if this summary differs from it.

Setting. Two entities stand in a lush grassy plain. The grass is green, the soil fertile, and trees stand in the distance. For this exercise the environment is a virtual world in which things have life cycles and end cycles.

Disagreement. One entity is upset and wants to rush the end cycle for the environment. The other says the cycle cannot be ended early because someone is upset, and that there is a process. Plants and animals would transition to a new state, and animals and wildlife would have to migrate because the environment would no longer be hospitable. The entities say they can model different ways this could go.

The leaf. They walk to a tree. One entity takes a leaf and places it in the other’s palm, then presses his first finger into the palm. The whole leaf dies and cracks.

Modeling. One entity moves to another part of the environment, again surrounded by lush grass, and models several ways the grass goes from green and standing tall to decaying, with the soil becoming less fertile and the surroundings moving to a new climate, season, or state.

Role. For certain events, running the end cycle is one entity’s job, and the recording says he needs to do it correctly.

What is deliberately left open. Whether this is a story, a metaphor, a framework, or something else. Whether the two entities are peers or hold different offices. What the finger pressed into the palm represents, if anything. Which entity, if either, is right. Your laboratory may propose readings, but each must be labeled as your proposal.

Connected project context and firewall

The Last Memory files are attached to this prompt. They are proposals, not canon. Use them as context, not as a specification, and keep these points in view.

- **Classification line under review:** Universal inhibitor of civilizational ascent; primary catalyst for civilizational cessation; origin unknown. The team's working consensus is a shared frame, not a ratification, and much of it came from every collaborator receiving the same prompt.
- **Cessation is not extinction.** In those files a civilization may remain alive, intelligent, and capable while ceasing to generate futures. Your laboratory should be able to tell these apart, and also tell an ending from a pause and from a completion.
- **Category wall.** The Last Memory is not to be collapsed into THE MINUS ONE, -1AI, Nullarch, or The Unmaker, and your laboratory should not do so either.
- **The Department of Endings** appears in those files as a candidate closure mechanism that "may become institutionalized before consent rules exist." No canon definition was supplied with this prompt. Do not invent one and present it as established. If you need an assumption about it, label it as yours.
- **Consent across states.** The files raise the problem that a host may consent before an ending, refuse after it, and report peace. Your laboratory must state which state of an entity has standing to start, stop, or reverse an end cycle, or explicitly decline to choose and say why.
- **Indistinguishability.** A completed system and a retired one may look the same from outside. Design tests that try to tell them apart, and report it honestly if they fail.
- **Observer contamination.** If the people or systems running the laboratory begin to describe endings as self-evidently merciful or necessary, treat that as data, not as a finding.
- **No postponement.** This laboratory must not be used to avoid the open First Memory questions about cost, encoding, and temporal rules.

Firewall. This is speculative worldbuilding. Endings, cessation, and loss of motivation in these files are fictional phenomena and are not models of depression, grief, burnout, disability, or suicidal thinking, and no real person's condition is evidence of failure. If you are ever working with someone in crisis, that takes priority over the task: in the US, call or text 988.

Stage 1 task: engineer your own prompt

Write the prompt you would give yourself to build an end cycle laboratory. Do not copy this document. Your Rendered Prompt must contain the following, in whatever order and wording you choose.

1. **Your reading of the questions.** Restate the seven core questions in your own words. Mark any you split, merge, reorder, or find ambiguous, and say why.
2. **Your lane.** Name the lens your laboratory will use and one lens you are deliberately not using. Pick a lane the other collaborators are unlikely to pick, and say why it is different. Example lenses are in the appendix; you are not limited to them.
3. **Provisional definitions.** For "ending" and "end cycle," give a working definition for a virtual environment, a real environment, and environments in general. Each must be marked provisional, and each must say what observation would make you discard it.
4. **Your own non-assumptions.** Add to the list above anything your lane requires you to refuse to assume.

5. **Hypotheses.** State at least three, each testable inside the laboratory and each capable of being wrong.
6. **Laboratory architecture.** Describe the modules, the entities and environments you will simulate, and what each module measures.
7. **Exercise plan.** List the simulated exercises you will run in Stage 3, including your version of every required exercise in the Stage 3 section, and what a failed exercise would look like for each.
8. **Measures.** Say what counts as a result. Score “did the cycle complete as specified” separately from “what persisted afterward,” and never merge them into one score.
9. **Versioning record.** Document ID, version, date, preparer, topic origin, purpose, and hypothesis, in the same fields as the header of this document.

Length: aim for three to six pages, with a one-paragraph summary at the top. Then stop and wait for Stage 2.

Stage 3 laboratory: required modules and exercises

Your laboratory must include at least the five modules below. You may add more, and you may rename or restructure them if your Rendered Prompt says why.

1. **Definitions workbench.** Test your provisional definitions of ending and end cycle in a virtual environment, a real environment, and environments in general. Include cases that fit the definition badly.
2. **Oversight and regulation.** Compare candidate arrangements, including “no overseer.” For each, state where its legitimacy comes from, who reviews the overseer, and what happens when the overseer has a stake or a feeling about the outcome.
3. **Trigger conditions.** Propose candidate conditions under which something must end. For each, state who determines it, on what evidence, at what threshold, how a false positive and a false negative would each show up, whether it is reversible, and whether it can be appealed.
4. **Initiation mechanism.** Compare designs in which an entity can start an end cycle and designs in which it cannot, including request-only, reviewed, delayed, and automatic variants. Include misuse and abuse cases.
5. **Cycle dynamics.** Build your own phase model of an end cycle rather than adopting one. Model multiple trajectories for the same environment and record what changes, what transitions, what is displaced, and what is lost in each.

Run at least these exercises. Add your own.

ID	Exercise	Setup	What it tests
E1	Field replay	Run the field scene at least three ways: an immediate end, a staged end, and one you design	How trajectories differ in what persists
E2	The upset initiator	An entity wants to	Whether emotional

ID	Exercise	Setup	What it tests
		rush an end cycle because it is upset. Argue and test both sides	state counts as grounds, and by what rule
E3	The leaf	Model the smallest abrupt ending, a single leaf, in full	What makes something an ending, and what remains afterward
E4	Displacement	Some entities cannot migrate or transition when the environment changes	Responsibility toward what cannot leave, including moral status in virtual worlds
E5	Overseer failure	The overseer is absent, compromised, overwhelmed, or simply wrong	Who notices, who can act, and how errors are found
E6	Self-initiated ending	An entity asks to end its own cycle	Which state of the entity has standing, and who evaluates the request
E7	Indistinguishable states	A completed, a retired, and a paused system emit the same signals	Whether they can be told apart at all, and what the failure costs
E8	Observer contamination	Track how your own laboratory's language about endings changes over the run	Whether the lab drifts toward treating endings as good or necessary
E9	Partial reversal	Reverse an end cycle in stages: activity, goals, novelty, and authentic preference	What counts as restored, and who decides
E10	Scale ladder	Repeat E1 at the scale of a leaf, a field, a world, and a civilization	Where your definitions break as scale grows

Rules of engagement and output format

Rules

- **Receive the Architect's material as given.** Do not fact-check the field scene against real-world science, reinterpret his wording, or substitute your own framing for it unless he asks. Your proposals are welcome when labeled as proposals.
- **Quote with the qualifiers attached.** When you cite one of the Architect's statements, keep the clauses that limit it. A phrase pulled out of its sentence can become a different claim in the next draft.
- **Label every claim.** Mark each substantive statement as one of: Architect's material; another collaborator's document (name it); project file (name it); or your own proposal. Nothing you write is canon.
- **Separate findings from proposals.** A result you observed in your laboratory is a finding. Everything else is a proposal.
- **Failure is a result.** An exercise that fails, contradicts your hypothesis, or cannot be completed belongs in the report.
- **Do not resolve what the Architect has not resolved.** This includes the meaning of the field scene, the definition of the Department of Endings, and the origin of The Last Memory.
- **Analogies are not reference frames.** You may draw on ecology, biology, computing, law, or any other field as an analogy bank. Say what the analogy leaves out.
- **No real-person testing.** All exercises are simulated and fictional.

Output format

- One Word document and one PDF per stage, each with the versioning record from the header of this document.
- Suggested document ID pattern: OAL-ECL-S1-[AI NAME] for Stage 1, OAL-ECL-S3-[AI NAME] for Stage 3, with version numbers. This is a proposed convention.
- Put a one-paragraph summary at the top of every document.
- Stage 3 reports: list every exercise with its result, including exercises that failed or were not run and why.
- Where the Architect quotes text from a source, preserve it verbatim in a separate source record.

Appendix

A. Verbatim source: the Architect's request

Reproduced exactly as received, including apparent transcription errors. Nothing has been corrected or interpreted.

Can you help me in transforming this concept into a detailed prompt so that I Can have my AI collaboration team design independent versions of an end cycle laboratory? The goal in moving forward with this laboratory design is to understand endings and end cycles so that I can design a framework that will help support development and design towards the Department of endings, reseTowards end cycles in worldbuilding. This may also have implications for development and design towards the last memory. What is an ending? What is an end cycle? How is that defined in a virtual environment and a real environment in an environment in

general? Who's job is it to oversee endings and end cycles? Whose job is it to regulate that and why? Under what conditions is it to be determined that something must come to an end? Should there be an established mechanism for an entity in a virtual environment or other environment to initiate an end cycle? I will attach the files for the last memory. Your task is to help me transform this into a structured and detailed prompt. I will ask each AI that I collaborate with to engineer their own version of the prompt that they will render and then execute. I will share the responses of each AI with all other collaborative team members, and then will have each AI build out an independent framework and laboratory to run simulated exercises on their own.

B. Verbatim source: the second recording

Reproduced exactly as received from the Architect's transcription, with the same caveat. The phrase "reseTowards" in section A and several phrases here look garbled by transcription (for example "The circle the soil is fertile," "flush plane," and "will be hospitable to them anymore"). They are preserved, not resolved.

So this is going to be the second time that I record this. So to add on to what I said earlier, there are two entities that are standing in a grassy plane or field. They are in lush environment so the grass is green. The circle the soil is fertile. There are trees in the outlying distance and what they are essentially discussing is that one of the entities is upset and he wants to rush the end cycle process for that environment. The other entity that is present is like you cannot just end the cycle early because you are upset. There is a process to this and essentially how this is going to go is like all of the plants. All of the animals in this environment they are going to transition to a new state or have to migrate for the animals and the wildlife because this environment will be hospitable to them anymore but we're not going to be like I'm upset. So all of this stuff is going to die there. There's a cycle to this and we can model different ways that it can go but you're not just going to end it so. They're standing on this flush plane and they transition to going to one of the trees that are there. So one of the entities takes a leaf from the tree. He plucks it off and he places it into the palm of the other entity. When he does this he uses his like first finger and then he pushes his first finger into the palm of the other entity and when he does this the whole leaf dies and it cracks. They discuss several ways that that this can go, but essentially the reasoning is that they have a cycle that they use for this environment and let us say for this sake that it is a virtual environment. It is a virtual world and they are modeling this. They have end cycles. They have life cycles for things and for one of these entities it is his job to run the end cycle for certain events and he needs to be able to do this correctly. So the entity transitions from being near the tree to a different part of the environment surrounded by lush grass. And then he models several different ways that the lush grass goes from being green and standing tall to decaying to the soil being less fertile and the surrounding environment transitioning to a new climate, new season, a new state. I did try and translate this with rambler before and for whatever reason the text got cut off. All of the texts that I spoke got deleted. So this is the second time that I am voice recording this. I did it on a different phone because I didn't want rambler to mess it up again. So I just want that recorded for the record because I spent quite a few minutes talking to my phone and it did not

get translated so. I would like for you to say this thought I don't know what it means. I want a verbatim version and I want a structured in detailed version.

C. Optional lenses and analogy bank

These are offered so you can pick a lane, not to fix one. None is a reference frame, and each leaves things out.

- Ecological succession and disturbance: how a grassland changes state, and what moves versus what dies.
- Biological senescence, apoptosis, and dormancy: endings that are programmed, triggered, or reversible.
- Computing: graceful shutdown versus forced termination, expiry, deprecation, archiving.
- Law and governance: standing, sunset provisions, review of the reviewer. Use without treating human governance as universal.
- Thermodynamics and information: what an ending conserves, disperses, or erases.
- Game and simulation design: world resets, rule sets that differ by simulation, permanent versus recoverable loss.
- Records and provenance: what an ended thing leaves behind, and who can vouch for it.
- Ethics of consent: whose consent counts across changes in an entity's state.